

LONE WARRIOR
Dhumal at the Churchgate station in Mumbai

THE FIRST BOX

In 1890, a Parsi banker working in south Mumbai's Fort area was tired of trudging back home over two miles to Mazgaon for lunch. Those days, there were nearly no restaurants. Enter Mahadu Havji Bacche, who worked as a porter for shopkeepers and at the docks. In Shobha Bondre's book *Mumbaicha Annadata*, we can see an archetype in Mahadu. He'd left the greens of Wajavne village in Pune's Khed taluka for the grime of the city, emerging from his pad in Khetwadi daily and transforming himself into human fuel. Mahadu would become the courier who delivered home-cooked dhansak to the hungry banker. Soon, more rugged and able-bodied men joined the new profession, streaming in from places like Mulshi, Maval, Ambegaon and Junnar, on Pune's outer layers, and Akole and Sangamner in neighbouring Ahmednagar. Hilly, often arid areas that produced a tough breed undeterred by arduous work. But more than the labour, it was their organic systematicity that would mark them out.

COVID-19 HIT THE DABBAWALAS HARD. THEIR NUMBERS FELL FROM 5,000 TO 1,300-1,500. THE TOTAL NUMBER OF TIFFINS HAVE FALLEN FROM 200,000 TO JUST AROUND 50,000

There was another vital ingredient to this evolving recipe. Religious and caste taboos governed food in the 19th century: touching something cooked at the hands of those outside your social *lakshmanrekha* was unthinkable. City life heightened caste anxieties, so home-cooked food would get fetishised. But there was a problem. The new immigrants were mostly male. "They had to eat out," says research scientist and food historian Chinmay Damle. "This led to the proliferation of caste-based *khanawals* (messes) around 1810-20. Entry was by ties of kinship or intimacy, where one member could vouch for another's caste location." *Khanawals*, often with women doing the honours in the kitchen, fed a whole epoch. The trend deepened as a new workforce streamed in, Mumbai's life as a commercial hub speeding up after the textile mills came in the late 1850s and the Suez Canal in 1869 spurred traffic at its port. The 1871 census showed a severe skew in Mumbai's sex ratio—612 women for every 1,000 men. The first restaurant for Hindus came only in 1883. By then, the *khanawals* had begun delivering lunch, their bosswomen transporting the dabbas themselves, says Damle.

Mumbai evolved a new urbanity over time. Caste taboos dissolved. For the dabbawalas, too, life settled down—it was no longer about men sleeping on the footpaths of Girgaon and Khetwadi. Their families moved in, even if their link with the village remained intact. Many got educated. But work is still like time-travel to the early industrial age: walking, cycling, pushing handcarts, to and from the luggage compartments of local trains. The expanded rail map means pick-ups and drop-offs now touch places as far-flung as Virar, Ambernath and Belapur in Mumbai's extended suburbs. With just a touch of digital modernity: in lieu of the old colour-coded regime to mark locations and personnel, there's an alphanumeric code. Yes, the younger white-collar workers preferred eating out. But the dabbawalas were nearly in sync, even as the times changed around them.

LUNCH / BREAK

It's Covid-19 that threw the picture of clockwork precision totally awry. "Companies downed shutters, several persist with work-from-home policies, food delivery apps proliferated…all that has brought down the number of tiffins to just around 50,000 now," says Ulhas Muke, chairman, Nutan Mumbai Tiffin Box Suppliers Charity Trust. The pool of dabbawalas has also thinned, from the pre-pandemic 5,000 to 1,300-1,500. At Churchgate, one of the busiest nodes in the exchange, lunchboxes have dipped from 4,000-4,500 to around 1,200, and only 43 remain of its original 80 couriers, says Ashok Satpute, the *mukadam*. One dabbawala can do the work four of his colleagues did in pre-pandemic times, says Gavande. "*Purvichi maja naahi rahili. Karaycha mhanun karaycha* (the fun has gone, now work is methodical)," admits